



Why Billy Zane was the bad guy

There's an interesting reason why Billy Zane was cast as the villain for Psych's finale. <http://digit.in/nov20-79>



The future of Psych

Dule Hill (Gus) speaks to Entertainment Tonight about the future of Psych. <http://digit.in/nov20-80>

shoved down your throat and over explained, like it's done in Ready Player One or Deadpool. They do not show the hero wearing the Buckaroo Banzai costume then go on and explain that the costume is from Buckaroo Banzai. Instead, they are just dropped lightly, and if you miss it or don't understand it, it is okay, you can keep going without understanding. You never know if something someone said is just another reference (that you did not get), or is pertinent to the case in some manner. In many cases, it is actually both. The references come in thick and heavy, and at times it is totally unexpected. This is an American TV show that ran on the USA network, but Shawn plays fantasy cricket and talks about choosing Sachin Tendulkar on his team. See what I mean?

REALISTIC TECHNOLOGY

There are many times in the series that you see both police and criminals using technology for either catching the bad guys or planning the next big heist. Every single time a computer is on screen, it has real software doing real things, along the lines of Mr Robot, and not CSI Miami. Like a loading bar is just a loading bar, desktops have cheesy wallpapers and websites have bad design. If you really look into it, it's a bad design in HTML. The only time in the whole series that something fancy is shown is when Shawn and Gus have to decrypt a file to solve a case, and the decryption is based on four different people having to hit just the right pitch and notes to crack open the file. Even here, the fake tech makes total sense because the software invented for the purpose keeps track of the four different voices (of the music group blackapella).

Another beautiful thing the series captures without really meaning to, is the invention of the smartphone in its current form. The iPhone released just after the second season started airing, and you can actu-

ally see the cast in the series and background characters move from feature phones to smartphones.

NATURAL DIALOGUES

One of the biggest gripes that audiences have with TV shows and movies is that the people do not really talk like you or me do. Seriously, just turn on the TV and switch over to one of the dying GECs still on air, or any of the regional language channels that are showing a serial, or go on Amazon Prime and pick any series apart from Psych, you will notice that a few things are odd about the way people talk. No one cuts into each other, people take turns talking, and whatever they are saying is always relevant to the story. Not so in Psych. The dialogues are not really improv, but so natural that it does not seem scripted at all. In fact, there are times when the dialogues are inaudible, muffled, unclear or in foreign languages without subtitles deliberately. Nonsense, gibberish and aggressive noises are also part of the dialogue. Shawn, Gus and the other characters constantly make conversational choices that are totally irrelevant to the story or the show. Two people may have long winding conversations to settle an obscure point, which are always funny. Typically, it can be something like which movie the ongoing events are similar to, or which actor played a particular part, or just the explanation for a viral craze such as Pottering. For those who do not know, Pottering is the act of jumping into the air with a broomstick between your legs, then snapping a photo so that you appear to be flying like Harry Potter. It is somewhat on the lines of planking or phooning. There is really no saying what sudden twist or turn a conversation will take, and the cast really talks like human beings.

REMAKES AND MASHUPS

These two are kind of bunched together because every episode

is also a remake, and many times it is a mashup of remakes. Every episode has a theme, and the title credits, theme song, transitions, cuts and cinematography are all given a treatment, based on the original show or movie. You never know what is going to hit you next, there is a Scooby Doo episode, a dive into rock culture, found footage movies or UFO abduction, and even musicals, yet all of these ridiculous episodes are totally realistic and even authentic. A recurring and underlying homage in the treatment is to the works of Alfred Hitchcock. At times though, the treatment can be completely original based on the theme. For example, in the superhero episode a fight sequence takes place where you can see the baddies getting beaten up with the "POW", "ZAP" and "WHIFF" in the frame, which when zoomed out, are shown to be a part of product ads, like a bug zapper or a detergent that is really powerful. Psych often comes up with its own unique take on things. In fact, Psych also remade one of their own episodes, in which Shawn argues that the point of remakes is to realise the full potential of a concept that failed the first time around.

The horror movie episode is a glorious mashup of The Shining, The Ring, The Omen, Rosemary's Baby and Ghostbusters. This is on par for the course. Psych also does the inventisizing slanguage thing, that is a very Whedonesque thing to do. Finally, there are so many guest stars that bring with them the references to the movies and tv shows that they acted in. To name a few, these are Diedrich Bader, Kenan Thompson, James Brolin, Jeffrey Tambor, Mena Suvari, Jaleel White, Rachael Leigh Cook, George Takei, Christine Baranski, William Shatner, Nestor Carbonell, Christopher Lloyd, John Cena, Val Kilmer, and yes, even Billy Zane. Tony Cox and Curt Smith appear as themselves. The series pushes all the right buttons when it comes to pleasing geeks. **4**